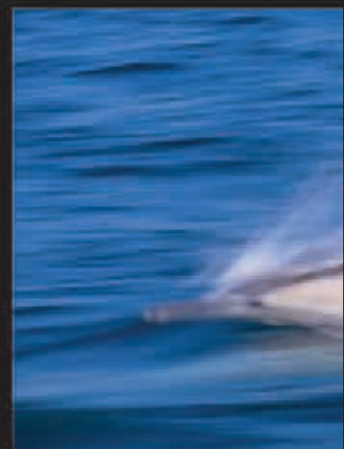


Skin

All vertebrates have skin, although it is often hidden from view by a layer of fur, feathers, or scales. However, in some animals, skin is the main protective barrier between the body and the outside world. This flexible body covering carries out many different tasks, such as keeping water in and germs out and helping animals to communicate or to hide. Skin is one of the fastest-growing parts of the body. It needs to be, because few other organs get so much wear and tear.

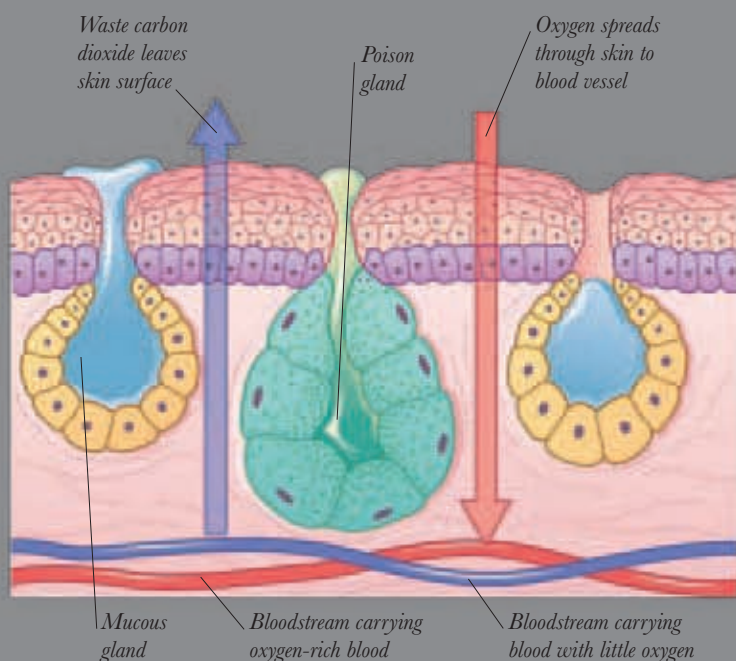


Common dolphin

Glands keep skin moist and exude poison onto its surface

Amphibian skin

Unlike human skin, amphibian skin has glands that ooze slippery mucus onto its surface. Many amphibians also have poison glands. These can be scattered across their bodies or concentrated in places where predators are most likely to bite. Oxygen is absorbed through the skin into the surface blood vessels, while carbon dioxide travels in the opposite direction.



Skin on show

Clinging to a plant stem, an Ivory Coast running frog shows off its extraordinarily vivid skin. These brilliant colors are a warning to predators, showing that its skin is smeared with poisons produced by special glands. This amphibian's skin is moist and paper-thin, and it can absorb oxygen, helping the frog to breathe both on land and when under water. The frog also has an area of absorbent skin on its underside called a seat patch, through which it can drink when sitting in a puddle. To keep its skin in good condition, the frog sheds the outer layer every few days and swallows the dead skin cells.